seven decades after the Second World War. But today, it is not only a critical global lifeline but one smoothly fusing into the waters of the Pacific. The actions of the major powers active in the Indo-Pacific speak volumes of their integrated vision. So, if we judge nations by what they do rather than what they preach, the picture is quite clear.

At the end of the day, the compulsions of interdependence and interpenetration have triumphed over outdated definitions. Concerns about the well-being of the global commons were also a factor. Contemporary challenges required like-minded nations to work together, especially once the US acknowledged the difficulties of going alone. The Indo-Pacific, in that sense, represents the reality of globalization as much as it does the results of rebalancing.

A significant contribution to the change in landscape has been made by India's Act East policy. Three decades ago, India adopted a more open economic model that helped forge closer ties with the ASEAN and Northeast Asia. In due course, this opening acquired other dimensions, including those of connectivity, security, education and societal exchanges. The domains of activity may be different, but starting from the 1990s, India's ties with ASEAN, Japan, South Korea and China have developed far greater substance and, consequently, higher priority. Australia was a subsequent happening, but political and security convergences allowed this relationship to play catch-up.

What began for India as a solution for an economic crisis has finally ended up as a strategic correction. Today, India trades with, travels to and interacts with the East much more than it has done since its independence. Here, too, there is a falling back to history as there is a long tradition of Indian maritime activity and presence, going all the way up to the Fujian coast of China. Those who have been to the temples of Angkor Wat, Borobudur or My Son will certainly attest to these linkages.

As we consider the emerging Indo-Pacific, its policy consequences obviously drive the strategic debate. From India's perspective, its embedding in ASEAN-led structures over decades has created a regular and comfortable interface with all the players. In fact, as India's vistas kept broadening eastwards, economic stakes were supplemented by political and security relationships with those partners that nursed common interests. It could be a global forum like the G-20 or a regional one like the IORA, all of them provided additional opportunities for greater socialization. Even